

Civic Education and the Decay of a Turnout Effect

Mara Lindqvist

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Synthetic document written for the AI for Research knowledge-base demo. Not a real paper, and neither the author nor the journal exists.

Abstract

Veremia reformed its secondary-school civics curriculum in 2011. I follow three cohorts of first-time voters across four national elections and estimate the effect of exposure on turnout. The reform raised turnout among treated cohorts by three to four percentage points at the first election. The effect decays and is no longer distinguishable from zero by the second post-reform election.

1. Introduction

Civic education is the intervention that democratic states reach for when turnout falls. Evaluations usually stop at the first election after exposure, which is the point at which the effect is largest. This paper asks what happens next.

2. Data

The reform applied to students entering the final two years of secondary school from September 2011. I use the Veremian Youth Panel, which tracks respondents from age sixteen and combines self-reported turnout with register validation for the subset of municipalities that release it.

Cohorts entering before September 2011 form the comparison group. The design is a difference in differences across cohorts and elections.

3. Results

Election after exposure	Estimate (points)	95% interval
First	3.6	1.4 to 5.8
Second	1.1	−1.2 to 3.4
Third	0.4	−2.0 to 2.8
Fourth	−0.2	−2.9 to 2.5

The turnout premium among treated cohorts is modest, on the order of three to four points, and it does not survive beyond the second election we observe.

Validated and self-reported turnout give the same pattern, with the self-reported series shifted upward by the usual margin.

4. Discussion

The first-election estimate is real and should not be dismissed. Neither should it be read as a permanent gain, which is how single-election evaluations are routinely cited.

Civic education appears to start a habit it cannot, on its own, maintain.

Whether reinforcement in later years would sustain the effect is a question this design cannot answer.

References

Ferreira, Tomás, and Priya Nair. 2021. “Does Compulsory Voting Make Better Citizens?” *Comparative Democratization Review* 12(3): 455–479.